



ARLINGTON PARK & RECREATION COMMISSION
17 Irving Street, Arlington MA 02476

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COMMISSIONERS:

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Memo

To: James Feeney, Town Manager
From: Natasha Waden, Director of Recreation and Community Services
Date: April 28, 2026
RE: Field Fee Schedule

The purpose of this memo is to provide clarification on Arlington's Park and Recreation fee schedule associated with field permits that are issued to individuals, teams, or sports organizations who utilize recreational fields in Town.

Background

The Park and Recreation Commission (PRC), with support of Arlington's Town Manager, first adopted a Field Permit Policy in 2002. The purpose of this policy was, and continues to be, to help provide guidance and transparency on the scheduling and permitting of fields and open spaces that fall under the jurisdiction of the PRC. A copy of the current policy available on the Town's website is included for convenience.

Community stakeholder engagement is an essential component to establishing a fair and equitable policy. As such, it has always been an integral part of the process for establishing/revising the field policy document and associated fees.

Fields/Open space/Playgrounds and other recreational spaces available and open to the public present financial challenges to the Recreation Department when it comes to charging or collecting funds to cover the cost of maintenance, management and upkeep to these spaces. While the PRC does charge a permitting fee for organized groups/teams/individuals allowing exclusive use of certain areas, it is a nominal fee and does not account for maintenance associated with other everyday community use by the public. The fees collected are intended to help offset some of the maintenance costs, but not all.

History of Field Fees

Although there have been several revisions over the years to the policy, the fee structure has always followed the existing tiered model. While the research I have conducted does not explicitly outline why certain fees were established at higher rates than others, I will note this type of fee structure is very common in municipal Recreation Departments throughout the Commonwealth.

It seems logical to assume that given Arlington's limited recreation spaces, the stakeholders involved in the fee setting process at the time were likely prioritizing residents/local user groups over non-Arlington residents/private non-profit groups who do not otherwise support the maintenance, management, and upkeep of these spaces through property taxes.

Additionally, it seems logical to assume that for larger organizations such as the youth baseball and soccer programs, establishing a price per participant per season would be more reasonable as opposed to charging an hourly rate per field given the number of fields and on-field hours necessary to accommodate larger organizations. However, charging a price per participant for an individual or single team with a smaller roster would be an insufficient contribution towards maintenance, management, and upkeep of the space.

Attached please find a chart which outlines fee changes from 2002 to the present day. Below is an explanation of the fee revisions:

- In 2002 the initial fees were implemented to help offset the administrative cost for the Recreation Department.
- In 2006, to address poor field quality issues, the Town contracted with an outside vendor for treatment of playing fields, including core- and deep-tine aeration, fertilization, over-seeding and slice-seeding. The Town committed to pay a portion of the cost, but the difference was passed on to the user groups and resulted in an additional \$6 fee to be paid to DPW who managed the contract.
- In 2012, at the request of user groups, the Recreation Department began providing portable restrooms at fields. As such, user groups were charged an additional \$2.75 to help offset the cost of placing and maintaining the portable restrooms.

Present Day Field Fees

Despite rising costs associated with portable restrooms and field maintenance over the years, the PRC has not raised permit fees since 2012. The fee structure has changed slightly to simplify the payment process for the field users so that they no longer make 2 separate payments, one to DPW and one to Recreation. Presently, the Department collects one payment and allocates the funds between DPW, Recreation, and Portable Restrooms.

Although there are no formal plans to change the fee structure at this time, the PRC acknowledges that these fees do need to be evaluated in the near future. However, plans to evaluate and/or change fees will include input and feedback from our user groups.

Arlington PRC Field Fee History 4/28/26

Group	2002 Rate	2007 Rate	2012 Rate	Current Rate
Arlington Public Schools and Teams	Exempt	Exempt for Rec Fee \$6 per participant/season -DPW maintenance	\$2.75/participant/season- Rec Fee, plus \$6 per participant/season- DPW maintenance	\$8.75/participant/season
Arlington Rec Arlington Youth Organizations Organized Town Leagues	\$2.50participant/season	\$1.25/participant/season Rec Fee, plus \$6 per participant/season for DPW maintenance	\$4/participant/season- Rec Fee, plus \$6/participant/season-DPW maintenance	\$10.00/participant/season
Private Schools located in Arlington	\$5/participant/season	\$5 participant/season Rec Fee, plus \$6/participant/season for DPW maintenance	\$7.75/participant/season-Rec Fee, plus \$6 participant/season- DPW maintenance	\$13.75/participant/season
Arlington Adult Organizations (groups with multiple teams)	\$15/game	\$15 game/field, plus \$6 per participant/season DPW maintenance	\$15/game/field, plus \$2.75/participant/season- Rec Fee, plus \$6/participant/season- DPW maintenance	\$150/Team
Arlington Residents	\$20/hr	\$20 per hr., plus \$6 per participant/season DPW maintenance	20/hr, plus 2.75/participant/season- Rec Fee, plus \$6/participant/season- DPW maintenance	\$25/Hour/Field
Non Resident youth Organization	NA	\$35/hr, plus \$6 per participant/season for DPW	\$35/hr, plus 2.75/participant/season- Rec Fee, plus \$6/participant/season- DPW maintenance	NA
Non-Residents Organization	\$35/hr	\$50 per hr, plus \$6 per participant/season for DPW	\$50/hr, plus 2.75/participant/season- Rec Fee, plus \$6/participant/season- DPW maintenance	\$50/Hour/Field



TOWN OF ARLINGTON **PARK PERMIT POLICY**

DRAFT 12.12.2017
UPDATED 2.19.2021; 3.23.2021

The Park and Recreation Commission has developed the following park permit policy to assist in the scheduling and permitting of the Town of Arlington Fields and Outdoor Spaces. The intent of this policy is to provide prospective field users with a guide on how to reserve a field in Arlington, clearly spelling out the expectations of permit holders by the Park and Recreation Commission. All fees assessed for field permits are used to offset direct field maintenance cost, assist with payment of portable restrooms, and provide a small amount of revenue to Arlington Recreation for the administration and oversight of town fields.

REQUESTS

Athletic Field Permits:

For Sports Organizations Seeking Permits

- A. Complete the Field Request Form- Fill out the appropriate field permit request form. Only the league president, athletic director, or appointed field scheduler shall apply for field permits.

<u>Season</u>		<u>Deadline</u>
Spring	(April 1 - June 24)	January 30
Summer	(June 25 - August 26)	April 30
Fall	(August 27 – November 25)	July 30

- B. Submit Rosters- All organizations or teams requesting permits are required to submit a registration listing of all participants in their program, two weeks prior to the first date requested.. Additionally, teams or organizations may be required to submit rosters upon request, t
- C. Submit Liability Insurance- Organizations must submit a copy of their organizations liability insurance (minimum of \$1 million dollar coverage) naming the Town of Arlington as additionally insured with their initial field application.
- D. Submit Final Schedule- A final schedule must be submitted to Arlington Recreation no later than 2 weeks prior to the first game date requested by the organization. This schedule shall include all home and away games for the season.
- E. Submit Payment – Payment is due as soon as season numbers are finalized.

For Individuals, Teams and Groups Seeking Permits

- A. Complete the online field request form at: Arlingtonrec.com or email the field request form to the Director of Recreation
- B. The fields should be requested a minimum of one week in advance
- C. Payment is due when field permit is issued.
- D. Permits will be issued after all sports organization requests have been finalized.

Picnic Area Request

Families seeking use of a picnic table area at a park for small gatherings and parties (under 50 people)

- A. Complete online request form at: Arlingtonrec.com
- B. You may search availability online at arlingtonrec.com
- C. It is the responsibility of the group to clean up after their use. Any items brought in should be carried out including trash.

Large Group or Special Event

For large gatherings and groups seeking to host public events

- A. Requests must be received a minimum of one month in advance
- B. Groups may be required to attend a meeting of the Park and Recreation commission for approval
- C. Additional review may be required by the police department, board of health, board of selectmen and/or other appropriate town authorities.
- D. Police Details and/or public works support will require additional fees.
- E. Groups that are issued a permit must review final details with the Director of Recreation or his/her designee, one week prior to the event.

- F. Groups must list all activities planned on the request form
- G. Banners or signs are not allowed per the Town of Arlington Zoning-By-Laws.

Basketball Court/Tennis Court

Public use of the tennis courts and basketball courts is handled on a first come, first serve basis. Arlington Recreation does allow some tennis court rentals through the playlocal application.

Permitting Priority:

- 1) Arlington High School teams and all Arlington Public Schools uses, Monday – Friday until 5:45 PM during the school year. Varsity games shall be played to completion.
- 2) Arlington Recreation Programs, Arlington Youth Organizations, Arlington Town Leagues and Sports Organizations, Monday – Friday after 5:45 pm, are defined as any organization that is requesting one or more fields for four or more dates during a specific season. Rosters must contain at least 80% Arlington Residents under the age of 18.
- 3) Private schools located within the Town of Arlington, Monday – Friday until 5:30 PM during the school year. Varsity games shall be played to completion.
- 4) Arlington Adult Organizations- Any Sports Organization requesting one or more fields for four or more dates during a specific season. Rosters must contain at least 60% Arlington Residents age 18 or older.
- 5) Arlington Residents –defined as any person(s) with either residence and/or employment in the Town of Arlington.
- 6) Non Resident - defined as any person(s) with residence and/or employment outside the Town of Arlington.

PARK POLICIES

Hours

Parks are open for the general public daily from 6:00am – 9:00pm .. Permits are typically issued from 7:00am – 9:00pm although special requests can be made to the Park and Recreation Commission. Lighted fields can be permitted until 10:00pm.

Duration

Parks are open for the general public use 12 months out of the year. Athletic Field are open for use from April 1 through November 30 (weather dependent). Use of Athletic Fields outside of this time is when the heaviest damage can occur. This is why impact use to fields will not be allowed during this time.

Field Closings (Weekday)

Field closings during the week will be updated by public works and posted to the field closing notification website. All field permit holders must sign up for these notifications.

Field Closings (Weekends)

Due to unpredictable weather conditions and the different effects the weather has on various fields, it's up to each individual organization to determine if a field is playable for a practice or a game. Groups are asked to use the Park Rules and Regulations as a guide to determining field conditions. If an organization or group determines that a field is unplayable on a particular day, it is the responsibility of the appropriate individual to notify their coaches and players and send an email to the Director of Recreation. Organizations/Leagues/Groups/Individuals who choose to play during inclement weather and cause damage to a field will be held liable for the damage and risk having permits for that field revoked and will need to pay to have the field repaired

Make-up Dates

Requests may be made for additional permits for make-ups if they cannot be accommodated within their existing permits. Arlington Recreation will make a concerted effort to find available field space.

New Sports Organization/Current League Expansion

A new sports organization is defined as any group that is not currently permitted field space from the Town of Arlington,

League expansion is defined as any growth in the number of teams or games that requires additional practice or game times or fields.

Any new in town league requesting Town of Arlington field space or any existing leagues looking to expand is required to submit a written proposal to the Director of Recreation. All requests will be reviewed by the Park and Recreation Commission.

Lighted Fields

Unless otherwise stated in writing by the Park & Recreation Commission all lights at lighted fields must be off by 10:00 pm. No inning, period, or quarter should begin after 9:40 pm. All necessary grooming of the field and equipment pick-up requiring the use of lights should take place prior to 10:00pm or deferred until the next day so that the lights are off no later than 10:00pm. All participants must vacate the field of play and parking areas within 15 minutes of end of games - No Loitering.

If for any unexpected reason, the lights remain on past 10:00 pm, a written explanation of the extended light use must be submitted to the Director of Recreation by noon on the next business day.

All lights will be turned on and off by the user groups with security check by a third party coordinated by the Arlington Recreation Department and paid for by the individual user groups. It is the expectation of the Park & Recreation Commission that light access will be limited to a select group of individuals within the organization.

The following is the disciplinary actions that will be taken for extended light use past 10:00 pm by any team in the organization:

- a. **First offense** – Groups will be notified by Director of Recreation of the incident and will be given a written warning of the violation.
- b. **Second Offense** – Groups shall lose light privileges at the field of the second offense for one permitted day.
- c. **Third Offense** – Groups shall lose light privileges for one week of permitted use at the field of the third offense.
- d. **Fourth Offense** – Groups shall lose light privileges for the remainder of the permitted season at the field of the fourth offense. If the fourth offense is at the end of the season then an appropriate penalty will be recommended by the Director of Recreation and approved by the Park Commission for the next permitted season.
- e. Any organization can appeal a disciplinary action. In which case, a public hearing will be held at the next Park & Rec Commission meeting to determine the appropriate action.

Artificial Amplification

Any use of artificial amplification must receive prior approval from the the Director of Recreation. A written request must be submitted at least one week prior to the event and shall include the dates and times requested the intended use and the reason for amplification.

Any amplification must also adhere to any and all noise regulations set forth by Board of Health and Town Bylaws. The Park and Recreation Commission may restrict the amount of amplification used, how amplification is used and the time of day amplification is used.

Violations

Any violation of the permit policy or Rules and Regulations can result in loss of permits and future permit requests. Possible fines may be applied in cases of destruction of property due to vandalism, misuse of permit, use of field without a permit or use of a field when fields are deemed closed.

RULES

General Rules and Regulations

The Town of Arlington Park and Recreation Commission, Director of Recreation, or an authorized representative retains the right to set conditions and requirements suitable for safe, reasonable, and orderly use of Town Parks. Violation of rules and regulations may result in the field use permit being revoked.

1. Any person (s) violating the established Rules and Regulations or constituting a public nuisance may be required to leave the premises.
2. Permit holders are only to use those parks specifically designated on the permit. There may be another group following yours, so it is essential that the park is vacated by the scheduled ending time.
3. Park permits are issued "AS IS": bases, balls, additional barrels and other equipment are not included in the permit.
4. All trash must be placed in proper receptacles or carried out. Groups are responsible for making sure the area is picked up at the end of their daily use period (including under bleachers, the perimeter of the field or the specific park area that they were using). Do not overstuff barrels or leave trash to the side of them.
5. Drills that result in excessive wear shall be conducted outside of the marked playing surface. Please do not use lines for impact running drills. User groups are expected to use good judgment to ensure unnecessary wear during non-game time activities.
6. Vehicles may not be driven or parked on turf areas, sidewalks, service driveways, or emergency zones, no exceptions.
7. There is no alcohol or tobacco consumption allowed on Town owned property.
8. There is no subletting of any field or facility in the Town of Arlington. Permit holder must be present on site during the field or facility usage.
9. Full responsibility and liability for property damage will be assumed by the permit holder.
10. The Town of Arlington carries no medical insurance for users of its facilities. Users participate at their own risk of injury.
11. There is to be no trespassing on abutter's property for any reason.
12. There is no grilling (either gas or charcoal) allowed at the parks in town.
13. Dogs must be leashed as per bylaw article 12, section 10 and clean up per bylaw, article 12, section 10a.
14. Use of Lights, Indoor Bathroom Facilities or PA System requires prior approval and additional charges.

Please note the following specific rules:

Special Events/Picnic Areas

- ✓ Permits are issued for a specific area, or space.
- ✓ Permits are issued for only the activities noted on the request.

Synthetic Field and Track Use

- ✓ Proper foot wear at all times on both the track and synthetic field.
- ✓ No metal cleats allowed.
- ✓ No items of any kind should be placed on the track surface, including bags, tables, and goals.
- ✓ Water only, no other sport drinks or beverages allowed on track or synthetic surface.

Baseball and Softball

- ✓ Soft toss against fences shall not be allowed.
- ✓ Standing water SHALL NOT be shoveled, bucketed, or swept out in any fashion. Grooming on wet fields shall be conducted by the park staff, or by approved individuals that have been properly instructed by the Park Supervisor.
- ✓ Only those amendments approved by Park Supervisor shall be used for water removal and infield conditioning.

Rainy Days/Wet conditions

All athletic grass surfaces in the Town of Arlington are closed for use by anyone during the months of late November – through March. To prevent damage and for safety reasons, the fields are not to be used in rain, wet, frost or frozen conditions. Please do not allow your participants to play in any unsafe conditions and report such conditions (if necessary) to the Public Works at 781 316-3301.

If there are questions as to whether or not a field can be played on, you should check the posting on the town website <http://www.arlingtonma.gov/departments/public-works/parks-fields>. Change in status due to changing weather conditions will be updated by 1pm for weekday evening play by the public works department. Weekend play and play after weekday posting should be made by the user groups using the following guidelines.

Guidelines for cancellation of activity on town parks:

1. If a footstep leaves an impression on the turf or if the grass is removed easily with a cleat, this is considered a wet field.
2. Standing puddles of water on a field, ground is water logged and/or squishy.
3. Footing is unsure and slippery.
4. Lightening or thunder is present or severe weather warnings are present.
5. Frost present or frozen fields.

User Group Responsibilities

Although parks may be open for use, weather and field conditions may deteriorate during use, in these situations, it is the responsibility of the user to determine whether or not to continue or resume use. Permit holders will be financially responsible for damage to parks when used during the above condition and results in damage.

Closed or restricted areas:

A closed field area is at the discretion of the Director of Recreation, Park Supervisor, or the Town's designee. Any section or part of any park, facility or field may be declared closed to the public at any time for any interval of time, either temporarily or at regularly scheduled maintenance intervals.

FEE SCHEDULE**Athletic Fields**

Category	Group	Rate
1	Arlington Public Schools and Teams	\$8.75/Participant
2	Arlington Recreation Arlington Youth Organizations Organized Town Leagues	\$10.00/Participant
3	Private Schools located in Arlington	\$13.75/Participant
4	Arlington Adult Organizations (Groups with Multiple Teams)	\$150/Team
5	Arlington Residents	\$25/Hour/Field
6	Non-Resident	\$50/Hour/Field

Park Permits

Category	Group	Rate
Picnic	Arlington Resident	\$50/rental
Picnic	Non resident	\$100/rental
Special Event	Arlington Non Profit Group	\$25/hr
Special Event	Arlington For Profit	\$50/hr
Special Event	Non Arlington Non Profit	\$50/hr
Special Event	Non Arlington For Profit	\$100/hr

Additional Fees

The following will require additional fees:

Light usage will be charge to the appropriate user groups. Charges will be based on time used and billed by the Recreation Department directly for usage.

Town providing Trash Barrels or other Public Works Support. This will be billed at the hourly overtime rate and the group will be responsible for the charge.

Police Detail will be billed at the established rate. Payment for the Detail will be paid directly to the police department.